misbehaviour). The concerned superintendent to look into the matter. His assistant's misbehaviour with the prisoners is not to be tolerated.

Round 10, 20 May 1993:

4. Storing of newspapers and magazines is of no advantage to the jail. Let these be circulated in the wards.

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The prison staff was called by the new IG (P) to attend a meeting. The situation was analysed. 'It became apparent that only a small section of the jail machinery was functional. There seemed to be no prison policy and there appeared to be an absolute lack of direction. There were no goals and no strategies. All we could see were problems all around,' recalled Kiran.

And given Tihar's dubious track record, each problem appeared more insurmountable than the other.

Tackling drug abuse became her first concern.

As Kiran herself explained: 'My day and night observation rounds of the jails revealed that a nexus of staff, drug peddlers and prisoner addicts were holding Jail 4 to ransom. The dispensaries were pathetically short of alternative drugs for prisoner-addicts and they had no option but to continue with their habits and become totally dependent on, and subservient to, the drug mafia operating within the jail. Nothing was possible, nothing could be done for the prisoners, till this rampant evil was rooted out.'

Exactly six months after she took up this challenge, Wilfred (the black American prisoner) could not conceal his amazement: 'Here's this lady who comes and tells us that the drug scene in the prison is bad. So, what else is new, we wonder. And, she says, she's going to put an end to it. She must be joking, we think, how is she ever going to manage such a thing? And now (with a clap of the hands) – poofff! she's done it.'

One ward in Jail 4 was converted into a deaddiction centre. Sunil Gupta, the deputy superintendent of the jail, observed: 'Ashiana is our drug deaddiction centre where prisoner-addicts are referred to by our jail doctors. Ashiana is a voluntary organization that has provided a staff of doctors, nurses and ward boys and has converted this barracks into a regular hospital. The patients undergo a treatment course of 15 to 30 days after which efforts are directed towards their rehabilitation. Earlier, there was no need of this place because "smack" was available quite freely with the connivance of the jail staff.'

But when asked was whether he not aware of this earlier situation and whether he made any attempts to check it, Gupta replied: 'I was certainly aware of this earlier but there was nothing much we could do about it. We could only report the cases to our senior officers and ultimately the IG (P)'s office would bury the file. A lot depends upon the leader. Now it's different. Staff who were involved in this activity have been reprimanded and some have even been jailed. Today we have a clear-cut policy towards drugs in jail. A new awareness has come in and I can say with conviction that today our jails are totally free of "smack".'

Now, over to Kiran to recount how she achieved it all:

The earlier situation in Tihar was shocking. As in Mizoram, here also the barriers of the prison were very porous. Those who were not drug addicts before coming to prison had become so